Time markers and sequencers in a biography

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to organise the events of a biography in chronological order using time markers (in 1920, at the age of 12, two years later) and sequencers (first, then, finally).

The idea in two lines: A biography tells the main events of a person's life in order. **Time markers** say *when* something happened, and **sequencers** show the *order* of events so that the text is clear and well linked.

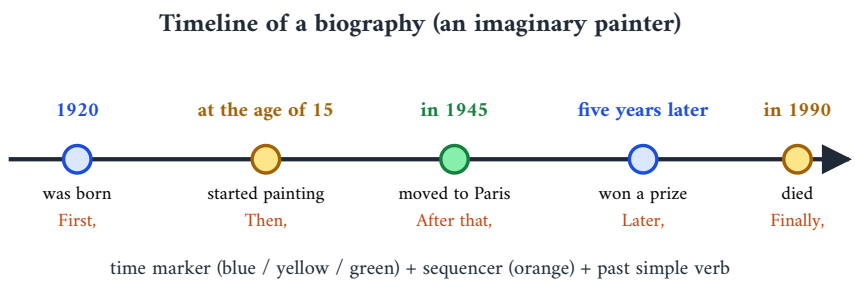


Figure 1: Each event on the timeline is introduced by a time marker and a sequencer.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Time markers with a date:** *in 1954, in the 19th century, on 5 July 1962.* Use *in* for years and centuries; *on* for full dates.
2. **Time markers with age or duration:** *at the age of ten, when he was 20, for three years, from 1950 to 1960.*
3. **Relative time markers:** *two years later, a few years before, at that time.*
4. **Sequencers** order the events: *first, then, next, after that, later, finally.* They begin the sentence and take a comma.
5. A biography follows a **chronological order**: birth → education → career → death (or present situation).
6. Verbs are mostly in the **past simple**: *was born, grew up, became, won, died.*
7. **Key verbs:** *grow up, graduate from, get married, move to, be awarded, pass away.*

🟢 Examples

1. Choose the correct preposition: *Ibn Badis was born … Constantine … 1889.* **Answer:** in Constantine in 1889. **Explanation:** *in* before a city and a year; *on* only with a complete date.
2. Link the events with sequencers: *he studied in Algiers / he became a teacher / he published his first poem.* **Answer:** First, he studied in Algiers. Then, he became a teacher. Finally, he published his first poem. **Explanation:** each sequencer opens the sentence and takes a comma.
3. Rewrite with a relative time marker: *She moved to London in 1960. She opened her studio in 1963.* **Answer:** She moved to London in 1960. Three years later, she opened her studio. **Explanation:** 1963 − 1960 = 3.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Wrong preposition: "*on* 1962", "*in* 5 July 1962". Years take *in*; full dates take *on*.
- Repeating *then* in every sentence. Vary: *after that, later, finally*.
- Writing "he borned" or "he was borned". The correct form is *he was born*.
- Mixing the order of events, for example the death before the career.

🟡 Quick review

- in + year / century; on + full date; at the age of + number.
- Sequencers: first, then, next, after that, later, finally (+ comma).
- Relative markers: two years later, a few months before, at that time.
- Order: birth → education → career → achievements → death.
- Verbs in the past simple: was born, grew up, became, died.

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